The Big Bads

Volume 12 — **locked.** One central villain for each saga, chosen for comic accuracy, no-nerf power levels, and how well each fits the real MCU slate.

Saga	Phases	Big bad	Defining comics source
The Infinity Saga	1-3 (2008-2019)	**THANOS** — Josh Brolin	*The Thanos Quest* (1990) and *The Infinity Gauntlet* #1-6 (1991), by Jim Starlin, George Pérez and Ron Lim
The Multiverse Saga	4-6 (2021-2027)	**DOCTOR DOOM** — Robert Downey Jr.	*Secret Wars* (2015), by Jonathan Hickman and Esad Ribi■, built up through Hickman's Incursions storyline (2012-2015)

1. Phases 1-3: THANOS, the Mad Titan

Why He's the Perfect Choice

- **He's Marvel's own villain, and he's never in rights limbo.** Created by Jim Starlin in *Iron Man* #55 (February 1973), he was born in an Iron Man comic, so it fits perfectly that the saga Marc-Anthony's Tony Stark launches ends with him.
- **The Infinity Gems are the perfect thread.** Six gems (Space, Mind, Reality, Power, Time and Soul) can be scattered across ten years of solo films and gathered for one finale. That's 60/40 serialization working exactly as designed.
- **The real MCU already chose him**, so the slate (Volumes 04 and 11) fits without forcing anything.

Comic-Accurate, Not the Movie Version

Element	Real MCU	Our MCU (comic-accurate)
Motive	Wiping out half of all life to “balance” an overpopulated universe	**Love for Mistress Death**, the cosmic embodiment of death. He wipes out half of all life as an offering to win her affection. The quieter and more frightening motive from the comics.
Origin	Titan, with few details	An Eternal of Titan born with the Deviant gene, son of Mentor (A'Lars) and brother of Eros (Starfox). Rejected by his own people.
Name of the gems	Infinity Stones	**The Infinity Gems**, originally called the Soul Gems
Gem colors	Space blue, Mind yellow, Reality red, Power purple, Time green, Soul orange	**As in *The Infinity Gauntlet* (1991): Soul green, Mind blue, Power red, Space purple, Reality yellow, Time orange.** Locked.
Who warns Earth	Hulk crashes into Doctor Strange's Sanctum	In the comics, the **Silver Surfer** crashes into the Sanctum. Fox controls the Surfer until 2019, so the Hulk takes that beat on screen, and the Universe Bible records that the Surfer exists and is on his way (the Rights Reservation Doctrine).
How he is defeated	The Avengers' time heist and Tony's snap	As in *Infinity Gauntlet*: his own hubris, **Nebula** seizing the Gauntlet, and **Adam Warlock** taking it from her. In the end Thanos is beaten by the flaw he can never fix: he believes he doesn't deserve to win.

No-Nerf Power Level

Even without the Gauntlet, Thanos matches Thor and the Hulk in strength, absorbs and projects cosmic energy, and is a super-genius who masterminds wars across galaxies. With the full Gauntlet he is **omnipotent**: he rearranges reality, erases half of all life with a thought, and overpowers cosmic beings like Galactus and the Celestials.

The road there: Loki in Phase One, recruited and armed by Thanos as in Starlin's stories. Adam Warlock is introduced before the finale, Nebula's arc is built across the Guardians films, and Mistress Death is felt in every Thanos scene. **Gems:** one or two surface in each phase, and all six are gathered in *Avengers: Infinity War* (2018).

2. Phases 4-6: DOCTOR DOOM, God Emperor

Why He's the Perfect Choice

- **He's Marvel's greatest villain.** Victor von Doom, created by Stan Lee and Jack Kirby in *Fantastic Four* #5 (July 1962), is a genius, a sorcerer, a monarch and a man who believes he alone should rule.
- **His story is literally the multiverse ending.** In Hickman's storyline, universes collide in “Incursions” and the multiverse dies. In *Secret Wars* (2015), Doom steals the power of the godlike Beyonders and builds **Battleworld** from the wreckage, ruling as God Emperor. It's the perfect blueprint for *Avengers: Doomsday* (Dec 18, 2026) and *Avengers: Secret Wars* (Dec 17, 2027).
- **The rights timing is perfect.** Fox controls Doom until Donohue buys Fox in 2019. The Rights Reservation Doctrine lets him exist in the Universe Bible from the start, and he arrives on screen right after the Fantastic Four (*The Fantastic Four: First Steps*, July 25, 2025).
- **The real MCU made the same choice** when it turned the saga toward Doom, so the real slate fits.

The Casting Irony: Robert Downey Jr.

Under our casting rules (Volume 02), Doom keeps his real-life MCU actor: **Robert Downey Jr.** His real casting announcement at San Diego Comic-Con (**July 27, 2024**) happens in our story too. Since Marc-Anthony took the Tony Stark role in 2006, the moment has a twist in the real-world story: the man who could have been Iron Man returns, 18 years later, as the villain who takes on the universe Iron Man built. Expect trade headlines, fan theories, and a very public, very warm Marc-Anthony welcome.

Kang Comes First

Phases 4-5 use **Kang the Conqueror** as the real slate did (Jonathan Majors in *Loki* and *Quantumania*). **Behind the scenes, Kang really is the planned big bad for Phases 4-6.** Real history is unchanged: Majors's conviction on **December 18, 2023** and Marvel dropping him that same day happen exactly as they did, and the saga pivots to Doom.

3. The Pivot: Making Doom Look Like the Plan All Along

LOCKED: when the pivot happens, it must feel as if **Doctor Doom was always the endgame**, to audiences, to the press, and inside the MCU itself. Kang becomes, in hindsight, the opening act.

The Secret That Makes It Work: "The Doom Contingency"

In 2006, Kevin Feige's Universe Bible, kept under the Rights Reservation Doctrine, lists Doom as *"the ultimate threat, pending rights."* Kang was the real plan, but Doom was never erased. Because of that, the story has **quiet, legally safe seeds planted for years**: never his name, his face or Latveria by name before 2019. They meant nothing until December 2023. Afterward, they mean everything.

Film / series	The seed (meaningless at first; reinterpreted after the pivot)
Iron Man (2008)	A Stark Industries sales ledger shows a refused order from an unnamed client: a *"sovereign in the Carpathians"* who wanted the repulsor patents. Tony's note in the margin reads: *"Never. Creepy mask guy."*
Iron Man 2 (2010)	At the Stark Expo, Hammer brags that an *"Eastern European monarch"* outbid him for a robotics firm. Pause the frame and the logo on the file is a stylized green cloak.
Doctor Strange (2016)	The Ancient One mentions a brilliant student *"who came for knowledge of the soul and left with a mask and a grudge."* This matches Doom's comic history of mystic training in the Himalayas.
Black Panther (2018)	Shuri flags a failed attempt to steal vibranium traced to *"a small European kingdom that doesn't officially trade with anyone,"* foreshadowing the comics' *Doomwar* (2010).
Loki season 1 (2021)	He Who Remains warns: *"My variants are the devils you know. Pray you never meet the one who isn't me."*
Doctor Strange in the Multiverse of Madness (2022)	The Illuminati describe Incursions, the multiverse-destroying collisions from Hickman's run. In the background of one dying universe is a **shadowed armored figure, watching**.
Ant-Man and the Wasp: Quantumania (2023)	Kang tells Janet his variants were scattered by *"a king who wanted the multiverse for himself."* Everyone assumes he means another Kang.
After the pivot: *The Fantastic Four: First Steps* (2025)	Doom's first full appearance, matching the real post-credits scene. Every earlier seed snaps into place.

The Comic-Accurate Bridge

The comics already connect the two. In the 1960s *Fantastic Four* stories, Kang, then Rama-Tut, wondered whether he was descended from Doctor Doom. Our MCU makes that canon: **the Kang Dynasty was Doom's opening move all along**. The Kang variants' Temporal War was a war against Doom's multiversal ambition, and their downfall clears Doom's path to the Beyonders and Battleworld.

The Real-World Story: Spinning It

- **December 18, 2023:** Majors is convicted and Marvel drops him. In a late-night war room, Feige pulls the 2006 Universe Bible off the shelf and opens it to the Doom page. *"We don't pivot. We reveal."*
- **July 27, 2024, San Diego Comic-Con, Hall H:** *Avengers: The Kang Dynasty* becomes ***Avengers: Doomsday***. The Russo brothers return, and Robert Downey Jr. unmasks as Doom. Marvel's line in every interview: *"Doom was always the endgame."*
- **The internet does the rest:** YouTube essays, Reddit threads and TikToks with titles like "Doom Was Here Since 2008" compile the seeds. Doubters point out the timing. Nobody can prove it either way, and the

debate is great publicity.

- **Marc-Anthony** plays it perfectly in interviews, swearing Doom was always the plan, then claiming Doom was also secretly in *Avengers: Brunch*.

Doom's No-Nerf Power Level

Doom's genius rivals Reed Richards'. He is a master sorcerer, trained in the mystic arts and later Sorcerer Supreme in the comics. His armor can stand up to Thor. He commands Latveria's army and his Doombots. With the Beyonders' power he becomes **God Emperor Doom**: the creator of Battleworld, the master of life and death, and more powerful than every Marvel cosmic entity combined. Nobody is nerfed, and that includes the man who would be God.

4. Tony Stark Survives (LOCKED)

Tony Stark does not die in *Avengers: Endgame* (April 26, 2019).

- **Comic-accurate ending:** following *The Infinity Gauntlet* (1991), Thanos is undone by his own flaw, Nebula seizes the Gauntlet, and Adam Warlock takes it from her. There is no sacrificial snap by Tony.
- **The gut punch stays:** as in the comics, Thanos kills heroes during the final battle, **Tony Stark among them**, in front of Pepper and the team. When the Gauntlet's damage is reversed, the fallen are restored and Tony comes back.
- **Why it matters:** it sets up the comics' great Iron Man vs. Doctor Doom rivalry (*Doomquest*, 1981; *Infamous Iron Man*, 2016) for Phases 4-6, ending in *Avengers: Doomsday* (2026) and *Avengers: Secret Wars* (2027).
- **The real-world story:** Marc-Anthony stays the MCU's anchor for all six phases. In *Doomsday*, his Iron Man faces Robert Downey Jr.'s Doom: the actor who took the role in 2006 against the actor who might have had it, twenty years later.

Why these two make a perfect pair: Thanos wants to *end* half of everything to win love. Doom wants to *save* everything so he can rule it. One saga is about loss and the other is about control, and both come straight from the source material.